

secure and provide more memory than existing SIM cards. UMTS networks, however, will still support the older SIM, so one can breathe easy.

Though W-CDMA is based on CDMA, it is not compatible with current CDMA cellular networks, which conform to the cdmaOne or CDMA2000 standards.

Also featuring on the list of 3G technologies for GSM networks is EDGE—Extended Data Rates for GSM Evolution. EDGE is just GPRS on steroids; it can even be set up on existing GPRS networks with just a few tweaks. It manages to send three times as much data in a time slot as GPRS, greatly speeding things up.

CdmaOne networks will be upgraded to the CDMA2000 1x EV-DO standard. Let us decipher this—the EV stands for ‘Evolution’, and the ‘DO’ stands for Data Optimised. So what this means is “CDMA2000, First Evolution—Data Optimised.” Instead of sending voice and data over the same channel as on the older CDMA networks, voice and data will be sent on different channels, increasing transfer rates to about 2.4 Mbps.

“I believe I can fly”—The Fourth Generation (4G)

With telecom consortia all over busy holding the world’s hand in its transition to 3G, nobody has yet sat down to formulate a formal plan for the fourth generation of mobile technology. However, there are big expectations. There have been a few tests for 4G systems internationally although India is yet to take trial runs with the system.

One of the key expectations from 4G networks is the availability of high quality audio and video that will render the mobile phone a portable entertainment centre. Higher data transfer rates will also mean that a James Bond style video conversation might finally be a reality.